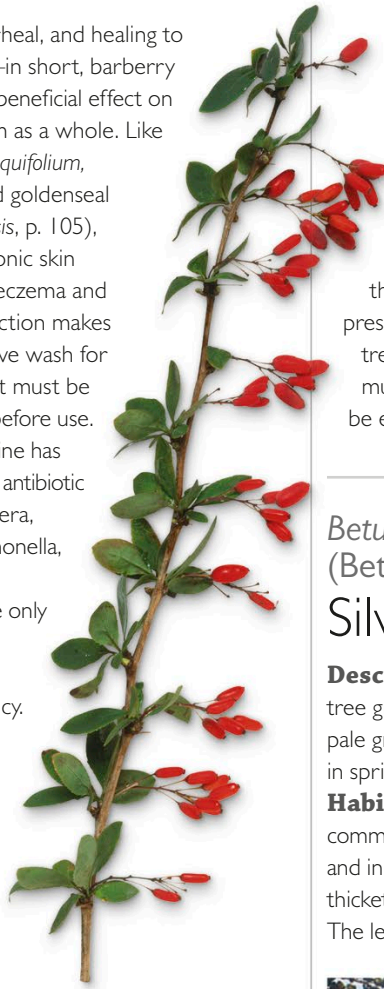


astrigent, antidiarrheal, and healing to the intestinal wall—in short, barberry has a strong, highly beneficial effect on the digestive system as a whole. Like Oregon grape (*B. aquifolium*, preceding entry) and goldenseal (*Hydrastis canadensis*, p. 105), barberry helps chronic skin conditions such as eczema and psoriasis. The decoction makes a gentle and effective wash for the eyes, although it must be diluted sufficiently before use.

Research Berberine has been shown to have antibiotic activity against cholera, giardia, shigella, salmonella, and *E. coli*.

⚠ Cautions Take only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy.

Barberry berries were traditionally used in a decoction to treat peptic ulcers.



Beta vulgaris (Chenopodiaceae) Red Beet, White Beet

Description Perennial with swollen edible red or white root, upright shoots, large deep green leaves tinged with red, and spikes of green-petaled flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Sea beet (the wild subspecies) is native to coastal regions of Europe, North Africa, and Asia from Turkey to the East Indies. Red beet is widely cultivated as a vegetable, white beet as a vegetable and source of sugar.

Part Used Root.

Constituents White beet contains betaine, which promotes liver regeneration and fat metabolism. Red beet contains betanin (also found in red wine), which is partly responsible for its immune-enhancing effect, and inorganic nitrate, which increases nitric oxide levels within the body and thus lowers blood pressure.

History & Folklore The *Materia Medica*, written by Dioscorides in the 1st century CE, recommends the following prescription for clearing the head and relieving earache—mix beet juice with honey and sniff it up the nose.

Medicinal Actions & Uses White beet acts to support the liver, bile ducts, and

gallbladder, influencing fat metabolism and helping to lower blood fat levels. Several clinical trials have shown that red beet juice (due to its high nitrate content) relaxes the arteries and lowers blood pressure in people with high blood pressure. A glass a day of juice will help to support lower blood pressure. Red beet juice is also thought to support immune function and is prescribed by herbalists as part of a cancer-treatment regime—though large quantities must be taken (up to 1 quart a day) to be effective.

Betula pendula syn. *B. verrucosa* (Betulaceae) Silver Birch

Description Handsome slender deciduous tree growing to a height of 100 ft (30 m). Has pale grey papery bark, toothed leaves, and catkins in spring.

Habitat & Cultivation Silver birch is common in Europe, in temperate regions of Asia, and in North America. It flourishes in woods and thickets, and is also planted as a garden ornamental. The leaves are gathered in late spring.



Silver birch is widespread in temperate regions throughout the northern hemisphere. Its leaf oil is used to improve eczema and psoriasis.

Parts Used Leaves, bark, sap.

Constituents Silver birch contains saponins, flavonoids, tannin, and a volatile oil that includes methyl salicylate.

History & Folklore Silver birch has been used as a medicinal herb in northern Europe and Asia since the earliest times. Its name is thought to derive from the Sanskrit word *bhurga*, meaning “tree whose bark is used for writing on.” In the highlands of Scotland, silver birch sap—tapped in the spring—was drunk as a treatment for bladder and kidney complaints.

Medicinal Actions & Uses An infusion made with silver birch leaves hastens the removal of waste products in the urine, and is beneficial for kidney stones and bladder stones (gravel), rheumatic conditions, and gout. The leaves are also used, in combination with diuretic herbs, to reduce fluid retention and swelling. Silver birch sap is a mild diuretic. The oil distilled from the leaves is antiseptic and is commonly used in preparations to treat eczema and psoriasis. A decoction of silver birch bark can be used as a lotion for chronic skin problems. The bark can also be macerated in oil and applied to joints for the relief of rheumatism.

Related Species The Himalayan silver birch (*B. utilis*), a close relative, is used to treat convulsions, dysentery, hemorrhages, and skin diseases.

Bidens tripartita (Asteraceae) Bur Marigold

Description Annual growing to a height of 2 ft (60 cm). Has toothed lance-shaped leaves, yellow button-like flower heads, and burlike fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Bur marigold grows throughout Europe and in other temperate regions, including Australia and New Zealand. It is found in damp places and near fresh water.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Bur marigold contains flavonoids, xanthophylls, volatile oil, acetylenes, sterols, and tannins.

History & Folklore The herbalist Nicholas Culpeper, writing in 1652, extolled bur marigold: “It helps the cachexia or evil disposition of the body, the dropsy and yellow jaundice, it opens obstructions of the liver, and mollifies the hardness of the spleen being applied outwardly.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Little used in medicine today, bur marigold is astringent and diuretic, and employed to treat bladder and kidney problems. It has a longstanding reputation for staunching blood flow, and can be used for uterine hemorrhage and conditions causing blood in the urine. Bur marigold’s astringency is beneficial in counteracting peptic ulceration, diarrhea, and ulcerative colitis.